

Bengalis and the love of potatoes

In West Bengal, the potato is **in the eye of a storm** — production shortage has **prompted** the state to stop its export to **neighbours** Jharkhand and Odisha, causing prices to **shoot up** in those states. **Bengal**, which produces about 90-100 lakh tonnes of potatoes every year, also **happens** to be among its biggest consumers — Bengalis consume about 60 lakh tonnes of potatoes annually.

Sharing might be caring, but Bengal's love for the **tuber** may be **at the root of** its potato **protectionist stance**. Like mustard oil and machher jhol, the two **go back a long way**. It **pops up** in West Bengal's street food like phuchka, in the alu posto that **precedes** the Sunday mutton curry, incomplete in itself without the **melt-in-the-mouth** goodness of the golden fried potato, or in winter, as an **accompaniment to fluffy** karaishutir kochuri. As for the Kolkata biryani, with its boiled egg and potato, most Bengalis will pay a **debt of gratitude** to Wajid Ali Shah: **Exiled** to Bengal, with his wealth fast **depleting**, the last nawab of Awadh is **credited** with having **fluffed up** the biryani with an egg and potato to replace the **copious** amounts of meat required for the **delicacy**. While this might not be entirely historically accurate, it is not difficult to see why falling production might **set off** a crisis in the state.



There is a darker **subtext** too, to Bengal's connection with the potato. British enterprise had introduced the root vegetable in the state's Hooghly **belt** in the late 18th century. The plant's **hardiness** meant that it would soon become widely **cultivated** and affordable. During the Bengal **Famine** of 1943, caused as much by Winston Churchill's policy failure as by **drought, inflation** and **hoarding**, it would be **potato peels** and **rice gruel** — food wastes essentially — that would provide **subsistence** to many and **spawn** a culture of **root-to-stem economising** that continues to this day. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

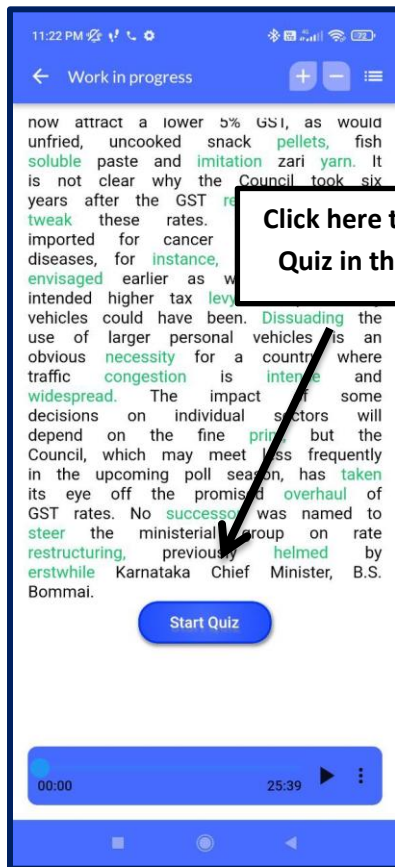
1. **In the eye of a storm** (phrase) – At the center of controversy, in a turbulent situation, under intense scrutiny **विवाद के केंद्र में**
2. **Prompt** (verb) – Cause, trigger, provoke, induce **प्रेरित करना**
3. **Neighbour** (noun) – Adjacent state, nearby region, bordering area **पड़ोसी**
4. **Shoot up** (phrasal verb) – Increase rapidly, surge, soar, escalate **तेज़ी से बढ़ना**
5. **Tuber** (noun) – Root vegetable, bulb, underground stem **कंद**
6. **At the root of** (phrase) – Fundamental cause of, underlying reason, basis of **मूल कारण**
7. **Protectionist** (adjective) – Restrictive (in trade), favoring domestic industries, limiting imports **संरक्षणवादी**
8. **Stance** (noun) – Position, attitude, viewpoint, standpoint **रुख**
9. **Go back a long way** (phrase) – Have a long history, exist for a long time, longstanding relationship **बहुत पुराना संबंध होना**
10. **Pop up** (phrasal verb) – Appear suddenly, emerge, crop up, show up **अचानक प्रकट होना**
11. **Precede** (verb) – Come before, lead up to, happen earlier than **पहले आना**
12. **Melt-in-the-mouth** (phrase) – Very tender, delicious, soft and easily dissolving **मुंह में घुलने वाला**
13. **Accompaniment** (noun) – Side dish, complement, addition, supplement **साथ में परोसा जाने वाला व्यंजन**
14. **Fluffy** (adjective) – Light and soft, airy, spongy, puffed up **फूला हुआ**
15. **Debt** (noun) – Obligation, owing, liability, dues **ऋण**
16. **Gratitude** (noun) – Thankfulness, appreciation, gratefulness, indebtedness **आभार**
17. **Exile** (verb) – Banish, expel, deport, send away **निर्वासन करना**
18. **Deplete** (verb) – Exhaust, use up, reduce, diminish **कम होना**
19. **Credit** (verb) – Attribute, ascribe, acknowledge, recognize **श्रेय देना**
20. **Fluff up** (phrasal verb) – Make lighter, increase volume, puff up, aerate **फूलाना**
21. **Copious** (adjective) – Abundant, plentiful, ample, profuse **बड़ी संख्या में**

22. **Delicacy** (noun) – Gourmet dish, specialty, treat, exquisite food पसंदीदा पकवान
23. **Set off** (phrasal verb) – Trigger, initiate, start, spark शुरू करना
24. **Subtext** (noun) – Underlying meaning, implicit message, hidden theme अंतर्निहित अर्थ
25. **Belt** (noun) – Region, area, zone, stretch क्षेत्र
26. **Hardiness** (noun) – Resilience, toughness, durability, robustness मजबूती
27. **Cultivate** (verb) – Grow, farm, plant, nurture उगाना
28. **Famine** (noun) – Extreme scarcity of food, hunger crisis, starvation अकाल
29. **Drought** (noun) – Dry spell, lack of rain, aridity, water shortage सूखा
30. **Inflation** (noun) – Rise in prices, economic inflation, cost increase मुद्रास्फीति
31. **Hoarding** (noun) – Stockpiling, accumulation, storing in excess भंडारण
32. **Potato peel** (noun) – Skin of a potato आलू का छिलका
33. **Rice gruel** (noun) – Thin rice porridge, watery rice dish चावल का पतला दलिया
34. **Subsistence** (noun) – Survival, sustenance, livelihood, means of support जीविका
35. **Spawn** (verb) – Generate, produce, give rise to, create उत्पन्न करना
36. **Root-to-stem economising** (noun) – Using all parts of a plant to minimize waste, complete utilization जड़ से लेकर तने तक की बचत

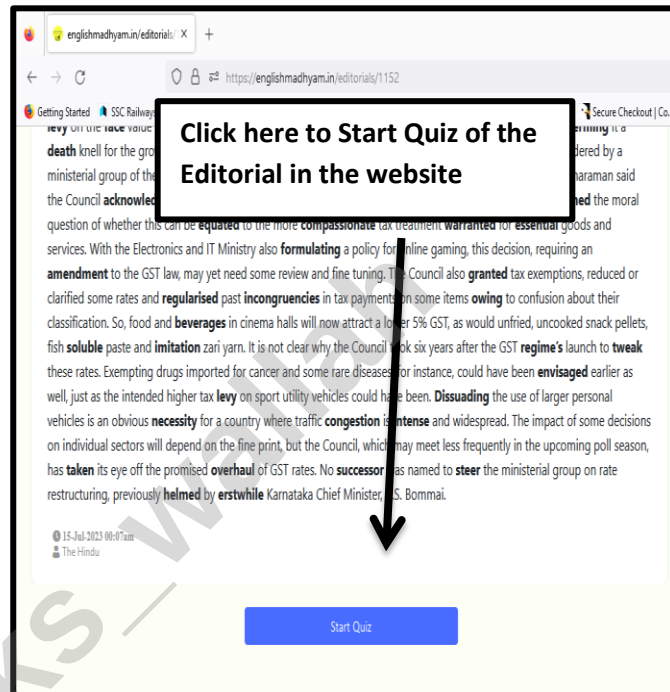
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Potato Shortage Crisis:** A production shortage in West Bengal has led to a halt in potato exports to neighboring states like Jharkhand and Odisha, causing price hikes.
2. **High Consumption in Bengal:** Bengal produces 90-100 lakh tonnes of potatoes annually but consumes 60 lakh tonnes itself, reflecting its heavy reliance on the tuber.
3. **Potatoes in Culinary Culture:** Potatoes are deeply rooted in Bengali cuisine, appearing in street foods like *phuchka*, dishes like *alu posto*, and seasonal favorites such as *karaishutir kochuri*.
4. **Kolkata Biryani's Unique Twist:** The addition of potatoes and eggs in Kolkata biryani is credited to Wajid Ali Shah, who adapted the dish during his exile in Bengal to economize on meat.
5. **Cultural Significance:** Potatoes have become synonymous with the richness of Bengali cuisine, playing a role in traditional meals and festive occasions.
6. **Historical Introduction:** Potatoes were introduced to Bengal's Hooghly belt by British enterprises in the late 18th century due to their hardiness and adaptability.
7. **Symbol of Survival:** During the 1943 Bengal Famine, potato peels and rice gruel became subsistence food for many, highlighting its critical role in survival.
8. **Root-to-Stem Economizing:** The famine also gave rise to a culture of minimizing food waste, a practice that continues in Bengal even today.
9. **Economic and Social Impact:** Falling potato production threatens both economic stability and food culture, making the crisis significant for the state.
10. **Potato as an Icon:** The tuber's integration into daily life, cuisine, and history underscores its importance in Bengal's identity.
11. **Protectionist Measures:** Bengal's halt on potato exports demonstrates its prioritization of local consumption over sharing resources with neighboring states.
12. **Street Food Staple:** From *phuchka* to *alu chop*, potatoes are indispensable to Bengal's thriving street food culture.
13. **Winter Delicacies:** Seasonal dishes like *karaishutir kochuri* and golden fried potatoes reflect the tuber's versatility in Bengali cooking.
14. **Colonial Legacy:** British agricultural practices laid the foundation for Bengal's dependence on the potato as a staple food.
15. **Crisis Sensitivity:** The potato's cultural, historical, and economic significance makes any disruption in production or distribution a sensitive issue for the state.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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